

To avoid paying stamp duty as a first home buyer, you must occupy the property for a continuous six-month period after the purchase.

However, if you don't move in to the property and lease it immediately to a tenant, you may still be eligible for the first home owner grant (FHOG) in the future for a home that you *will* live in. It's best to check the FHOG criteria, state by state. You may want to rentvest if you have been toying with getting into the market but are short of desirable choices in suburbs that tickle your fancy.

### **Could you be this sort of buyer?**

- You are living at home with Mum and Dad, and they are happy for you to stay on; you also don't have the urge to move out, given you can live rent-free, but you want to start your property portfolio.
- You are someone renting in a suburb you cannot afford to buy into. You're not prepared to take the hit of moving somewhere you don't want to, as you want to retain your lifestyle, close to work, for example – but you still want to get into the property market.

If your rental payments are less than potential mortgage repayments – and this is not a given, as renting has become more expensive, narrowing the gap between leases and mortgages – you can use your cash flow to secure a mortgage for an investment property.

There is a cadre of mortgage brokers and buyers' advocates who specialise in rentvesting – a quick google will throw up dozens of picks – and they can walk you through the legalities and requirements, including occupancy laws and stamp duty rules, because it's not as simple as buying it, leasing it and rubbing your hands together.

### **Master of your mortgage**

Buyers' advocate Cate Bakos, who specialises in finding first homes, says the right mortgage cuts back on mistakes made in the search for the right property.

'Recognising that no mortgage product is "forever" and loan portability as our lives change is important,' she says. 'Loan portability' is a feature